

Pressure & Stress

Feeling pressure is normal — every top athlete feels it. What makes the difference is how you handle it. Players discover their stress signals and learn to regulate them.

 **Group + individual**

3 exercises

Evidence-based



What will you take with you today?

01

You recognise the **physical and mental signals** of stress in yourself.

02

You master at least **one breathing technique** to regulate activation.

03

You can name the difference between **problem-focused and emotion-focused coping**.

Crocker et al. (2015) — review of 92 studies on coping in youth sport: flexible coping strategies show the strongest link with performance and wellbeing. *International Journal of Sport Psychology*.

Balban et al. (2023) — randomised study: cyclic breathing (4 sec in, 4 sec hold, 8 sec out) reduces stress significantly more than mindfulness meditation. *Cell Reports Medicine*.

Hanton et al. (2009) — competition anxiety becomes facilitating or debilitating based on how the athlete interprets the stress response, not on its intensity.

1

Box Breathing

Breathe together as a group — 4 sec in, 4 sec hold, 4 sec out, 4 sec wait

BREATHE TOGETHER

Stand in a circle, close eyes. Lead aloud: 'In... 2, 3, 4. Hold... 2, 3, 4. Out... 2, 3, 4. Wait... 2, 3, 4.' Repeat 4 times.

LOGBOOK

Players practise Box Breathing 3x this month before a session or match and note how they felt before and after (1-10).

REFLECTION QUESTION

'What do you notice in your body after four rounds? What changes?'

Use this in matches too: at a time-out give 30 seconds to breathe together before you speak tactics — more information sticks.

2

Stress Diary

What did you feel, think, and do? Write it down after your next match

Physical and emotional — what happened in your body and mind just before or during the pressure?

Which thoughts ran through your mind? Write them honestly, without making them nicer.

How did you react to the pressure? This diary is private — the coach does not push you to share.

Private: say explicitly 'This diary is for you alone.' After two weeks: 'Who discovered patterns?' — without asking for content.

3

Worst Case
Best Case

Think of an upcoming situation that makes you nervous — write the three scenarios

The worst imaginable scenario. Write it out concretely — what would actually happen?

The best imaginable scenario. What does it look like if all goes well?

What is most likely to actually happen? Almost always somewhere between worst and best.

Coach question: 'Has your Worst Case ever actually happened?' Almost always the answer is no — putting it in perspective is the goal.

Billie Jean King — 39x Grand Slam Champion

Tips for this session



Tip 1 — Normalise stress

Say literally: 'Every pro feels this. You too. It's not weakness.' Young players often think they're the only one who is nervous.



Tip 2 — Breathe in the match

Use Box Breathing in real situations. At a time-out, give space to breathe before discussing tactics.



Tip 3 — Watch 'no stress'

Players who never seem to feel stress: this may be apathy or a defence. Check in individually: 'How are you really?'



Careful: adding pressure

Don't say 'You should be able to do this.' That increases the very stress. Use: 'What do you need to stay calm?'

5' Explain theme: stress and coping styles

10' Worst Case Best Case in pairs
min

7' Group reflection and closing

⚡ TEAM RITUAL - THE COMPASS WORD

Ask players to reflect on their role in the team. Which roles do they fill — beyond their position on the field?